

Family HORRORS

The tragedy of the Bhuttos reveals the darker side of Pakistan's democratic struggle

| By S. Prasannarajan |

SONGS
BLOOD
SWORD

SONGS OF BLOOD
AND SWORD:
A DAUGHTER'S
MEMOIR

by FATIMA BHUTTO
Viking

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When you are a lone child in the haunted hall of history, memory is liberation. Fatima Bhutto, at 28, is the remembering child who carries within her the sighs and sorrows of her ancestry, which itself is a subcontinental saga of power and paranoia, of romance and betrayal, of dynastic impulses and totalitarian temptations, of democratic transgressions and familial bloodlust. As the sanguineous jacket description of this debutante memoirist mythifies—granddaughter of the executed Zulfikar Ali Bhutto; daughter of the assassinated Murtaza Bhutto; and the niece of assassinated Benazir Bhutto and the poisoned Shahnawaz Bhutto—she, the residual poignancy of the House of Bhuttos, listens to the whispers of the dead. In *Songs of Blood and Sword*, she becomes their chosen stylus. “You should write a book,” Fatima would ask her father on their return from his 42nd birthday dinner at the Avari Hotel in Karachi. “I can’t write a book while I’m alive,” he would protest. “What do you mean? You have to do it—write a book about your life, Papa, it would be so interesting,” the 14-year-old would insist. “No I can’t. You’ll do it for me. You can write the book on my life,” he would say. By the next evening, on September 20, 1996, Mir Murtaza would be shot outside his residence, 70 Clifton, the most famous private address in Pakistan.

This is that book—and more. Murtaza, the younger brother of Benazir, was the prodigal son: the rebel, the revolutionary, the romantic, the martyr. In the patriarchal Pakistani politics, he is the Bhutto unrealised, the heir outcast, let down by her big sister Benazir, Fatima’s *wadi bua*, ambitious and power-crazy, and finally killed by her cops—that is the Murtaza that emerges from her daughter’s narrative which may sentimentalise history but never fails in its primary mission: restoration of her father, who mostly played out his romance in the grey remoteness of Kabul and Damascus, as a victim in the hoary lore of the Bhuttos. Murtaza and his younger brother Shahnawaz would become the roving revolutionaries for justice during the imprisonment and after the execution of their father, and their benefactors would be some of the first-rate

FATIMA BHUTTO



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